

DIGGING UP DIRT Sand mining at Bisalpur dam in Tonk, Feb. 19, 2024

PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

▶ RAJASTHAN

THE RAPE OF A RIVER

Illegal sand mining is serially destroying the Chambal, one of India's most pristine river systems. Even Supreme Court admonitions fail against entrenched interests

By **Rohit Parihar**

THE CRIME IS SO MUCH THE DEFAULT NORM, so deeply ingrained in the local ecologies of power, that it goads even the highest court to cross lines in the sand. In mid-April, it was an irate Supreme Court that threatened to go beyond judicial oversight and wade right into the slush of law enforcement. Even paramilitary deployment could be considered, it said, taking suo motu cognisance of the killing of two forest personnel in the Chambal belt. Dacoits? Well, the court did use the metaphor, but sand mafia kingpins are not exactly horseback desperadoes who merely ride rough over the ravines. Quite the opposite.

For a furtive job, sand mining is remarkably sedentary—as long as the site has life. On the dry banks and sand bars of the Chambal, they use heavy machinery like bulldozers and JCBs to gouge out their grains of yellow gold, sweeping away *gharial* and turtle nests, carrying away a part of their habitat forever in their front-end loaders.

From the riverbed, they suck up tonnes of slurry with diesel-run suction dredgers, cutting deep wounds into what's still one of India's most pristine rivers. The raw sand gets piled on to tractor-trolleys that move out in convoys in the dark. All the way to modern India's glitzy buildings—you might be sitting in one of them as you read this.

On April 2, the court had stayed a controversial Rajasthan notification, issued in December, that denotified 732 hectares of the National Chambal Sanctuary. Calling it prima facie illegal, the court said critical wildlife habitats could not be sacrificed for the reckless harvesting of sand.

FOOTSOLDIERS FELLED

But nothing changed on the ground. Hundreds of trucks still ferry illegally mined sand across the region—a sign that enforcement itself could be compromised. Except when the occasional footsoldier tries to do his job. In Janu-